

Research & Strategy Brief

Deep-dive on the competitive landscape, judging patterns from comparable open-source hackathons, and a full catalog of winnable project ideas mapped to each track.

open source

de-googling

interoperability

data ownership

local-first

Event

reclaimhackathon.com

Organizer

Jordan Open Source
Association (JOSA)

Hacking Period

Jul 18 – Aug
1, 2026

Prepared

July
2026

What We're Actually Competing In

A themed open-source hackathon judged by OSS maintainers and community leaders — not a generic startup pitch competition. Scope discipline and real usage matter more than ambition.

1000

JOD · 1ST PLACE

500

JOD · 2ND PLACE

250

JOD · 3RD PLACE

≤4

TEAM SIZE

Timeline

DATE	MILESTONE
Jun 22	Registration opens (proposed project idea required)
Jul 13	Registration closes
Jul 18	Opening ceremony
Jul 18 – Aug 1	Hacking period
Aug 1	Submissions due (project, docs, demo)
Aug 1 – Aug 8	Judging by OSS maintainers & community leaders
Aug 8	Closing ceremony / winners announced

Eligibility Criteria (what's scored)

01 · Open Source

OSI-approved license (MIT, GPLv3, Apache 2.0).

02 · Real Problem, Real Users

Must name the problem, who faces it, why existing solutions fall short.

03 · Practicality

Compatible with existing workflows — sync/bridge, don't force migration.

04 · Realistic Scope

One specific problem, not an entire platform. Must be maintainable post-event.

05 · User Ownership & Privacy

Data portability, transparency, privacy by design.

06 · Extensibility

APIs, webhooks, plugin systems, CLI, import/export formats.

07 • AI Usage

AI-assisted is fine. "AI slop" — unmaintainable AI-generated code — is penalized/disqualified.

⚠ Disqualifiers

Buzzwords w/o substance, vague problem statement, unrealistic scope, privacy violations, AI slop.

Track Definitions

#	TRACK	FOCUS
1	UX & Accessibility "Grandma-Friendly"	Open alternatives to simple everyday tools (email, messaging, photos) designed for non-technical, real people. Onboarding simplification, mobile-first, beginner-friendly interfaces.
2	Open Infrastructure Tooling	Deployment, server management, auth/OAuth, self-hosting, federated services — make running your own infra as easy as logging into a social app.
3	Communication Freedom Interoperability & Bridges	Keep using popular apps/platforms without invasive big-tech practices or forcing contacts to migrate. Connect closed and open ecosystems.
4	Local-First & Data Ownership	Painless migration off centralized platforms: export/import, sync, backup, portability, offline-first and P2P architectures.

What They Told Us "Good" Looks Like

Six projects JOSA cited as inspiration. Read literally, they're a map of exactly what the judges consider exemplary — and three of six share one identical architecture.

PROJECT	MECHANISM	MAPS TO TRACK	LINK
nchat	Unifies Telegram/WhatsApp/Signal behind one terminal client — per-protocol adapter, common interface.	3	github.com/d99kris/nchat ↗
matterbridge	N-to-N chat bridge across ~15 platforms. Config-driven, REST API, no central server.	3	github.com/42wim/matterbridge ↗
RSS-Bridge	Per-site scraper adapter turns any site without RSS into a structured feed.	3	github.com/RSS-Bridge/rss-bridge ↗
YunoHost	Packages sysadmin complexity into installable "apps" + unified SSO/admin layer.	2	github.com/YunoHost/yunohost ↗

Syncthing	P2P block-level file sync, zero central server, own wire protocol (BEP).	4	github.com/syncthing/syncthing ↗
Pixelfed	ActivityPub federation — data/identity portable across servers, not one company.	4	github.com/pixelfed/pixelfed ↗

Signal: 3 of 6 cited projects (nchat, matterbridge, RSS-Bridge) are the identical shape — *N incompatible backends, one adapter interface*. 2 of 6 (Syncthing, Pixelfed) hinge on *no central server + portable data*. Only 1 (YunoHost) is a pure complexity-wrapper. **Zero** map to Track 1 — it's the one track with no worked example, meaning less pattern-matching precedent for judges but also least competitive pressure.

What Wins at Comparable Events

Researched the closest real analogs: hackathons judged by OSS maintainers on decentralization / data-ownership / interoperability themes. Reclaim has no local precedent — it's JOSA's first themed hackathon of this kind — so international touchstones are the best signal available.

Closest comparable events

EVENT	WHAT / WHY IT'S RELEVANT
FOSS Hack (India, annual)	Best direct analog — FOSS-only, judged by FOSS maintainers, 2023–2025 editions with published results and judge comments. → forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2024-results/3964 ↗ → forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2025-results/5541 ↗
Solid / ODI Hackathon	Two-day sprint around Tim Berners-Lee's Solid data pods. Winning team translated an abstract protocol into one concrete data-ownership use case. → ua.news/en/technologies/komanda-sends-viishla-do-finalu-khakatonu-z-prototipom-financial-pod-na-zapusku-odi-solid26 ↗
Decentralized Web Hackathon (Devpost, 2019)	Published judging rubric: Usefulness, Tech Quality, Sponsor-Tech Integration, "WOW factor." → decentralized-web.devpost.com ↗
Matrix.org bridge hack-days	Bridge-building is a recurring theme, not a one-off — TADHack 2015 & a 2025 WhatsApp ↔ Matrix hackathon. → matrix.org/blog/2015/06/16/global-tadhack-matrix-hacks ↗ → foss.events/2025/04-26-community-organiser-matrix-hackathon.html ↗
Mozilla Global Sprint	Explicitly framed around "erosion of privacy, centralization of power." Non-competitive (no winners) — useful for tone, not judging signal. → blog.mozilla.org/en/mozilla/news/mozillas-giant-distributed-open-source-hackathon ↗

Named winning projects & why they won

- **Batwara** (FOSS Hack 2024, ₹50k) — self-hostable Splitwise clone. Judged: "well documented, complete application." A narrow, boring, real pain point, fully finished.
→ forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2024-results/3964 ↗
- **Zide** (FOSS Hack 2024, top prize) — cross-platform pixel-art editor, Tauri-packaged. Won on design polish and packaging, not novelty. → forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2024-results/3964 ↗
- **Sheeja** (FOSS Hack 2024, top prize, tied) — hardware device. Won on "innovative and novel idea" + a great live demo. → forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2024-results/3964 ↗

- **Clue Glue** (FOSS Hack 2024, ₹50k) — self-hostable feedback board. Judged on "completeness."
→ forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2024-results/3964 ↗
- **goboscript** (FOSS Hack 2025) — text language compiling to Scratch. Won partly because judges could see *live commit activity during judging* — read as authentic building.
→ forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2025-results/5541 ↗
- **Serenade** (FOSS Hack 2025) — competent open-source music player, but capped at mid-tier: "useful though lacking in originality." Competence alone isn't enough. → forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2025-results/5541 ↗
- **Wroclaw-Transit** (FOSS Hack) — transit transparency tool built on the open GTFS standard. Rewarded specifically for standards-based interop over a custom format. → forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2025-results/5541 ↗
- **"Financial Pod"** (Solid/ODI hackathon) — consolidated a user's own bank data into their own Solid pod. Won by making an abstract protocol concrete and personal, not by demoing the protocol itself.
→ ua.news/en/technologies/komanda-sends-viishla-do-finalu-khakatonu-z-prototipom-financial-pod-na-zapusk-u-odi-solid26 ↗

Judging patterns that repeat across every event studied

- **Completeness beats ambition, universally.** Every winner citation used words like "complete," "well-documented," "polished." No half-built ambitious entry placed anywhere, in any year.
- **A working demo is non-negotiable.** No event in this space rewards a deck over a running build.
- **Novelty is a tiebreaker on top of completeness — not a substitute for it.** You need real polish, real novelty, or ideally both. Neither alone at a mediocre level wins (see Serenade).
- **Narrow real pain point > ambitious platform, with zero exceptions found.** Every traceable winner across every event solved one specific, small, relatable problem.
- **OSS-maintainer judges pattern-match against their own project's origin story.** RSS-Bridge, matterbridge, Syncthing, nchat all began as one maintainer scratching one specific itch — not "alternative to a whole company."
- **Standards-based interoperability is explicitly rewarded** (Wroclaw-Transit / GTFS) — directly parallels Reclaim's own "extensibility" criterion.
- **Visible incremental commits during the event read as authenticity** — directly relevant to the "AI slop" disqualifier; maintainers will likely check git history.

Bottom line: pick one narrow lock-in seam real Jordanian/Arabic-speaking users hit today, bridge or replace it (not rebuild the whole thing), ship a working self-hostable demo with clean docs and live commit history, expose one clean extension point. Favor "boring and complete" over "clever and half-built."

All Winnable Ideas, By Track

Every idea below is shaped to match the judging patterns above: one narrow seam, one clear inspiration lineage, a concrete "why" tied to the eligibility criteria.

1

UX & Accessibility / Grandma-Friendly

No worked example cited by JOSA — wide open, but riskier to judge without a precedent to anchor to.

Grandma-Mode Front-End for Matrix or Pixelfed

inspo: [Pixelfed](#) / Matrix protocol

Why: strips device-linking, backup-phrase and instance-picking jargon down to a 3-tap flow. Satisfies "real problem, real users" directly — elderly users leaving WhatsApp/Facebook is a genuine, nameable pain point, and the scope is bounded (a UX layer, not a new protocol).

Single-Button "Send Photo to Family" Client

inspo: Nextcloud / [Pixelfed](#) backend

Why: voice-first or one-tap client on top of an existing open backend. The entire project *is* the UX simplification, keeping scope realistic while still being "extensible" (thin client on a documented API).

Fediverse Onboarding Wizard

inspo: [Pixelfed](#) / Mastodon instance-picker pain

Why: collapses the "which server do I even join" decision into a guided 3-step flow. Directly attacks the #1 known adoption blocker for federated alternatives — very demoable, very bounded.

2

Open Infrastructure Tooling

YunoHost's shape: package and wrap complexity, don't reinvent the underlying service.

One-Command "Leave Big Tech" Bundle

inspo: [YunoHost](#)

Why: bundles 2–3 open alternatives (Pixelfed + Syncthing + Matrix) behind a single YunoHost-style SSO login. Directly mirrors the single cited example for this track, which lowers judging risk while still being a real, complete, self-contained deliverable.

OAuth/SSO Proxy for Self-Hosted Apps

inspo: [YunoHost](#)'s SSOWAT layer

Why: lets self-hosted open apps keep "login with Google" convenience while data lives outside Google. A narrow, single-seam bridge for *identity* specifically — very realistic scope, satisfies "practicality" (works with existing workflows).

Federated-Service Bootstrap Tool

inspo: [YunoHost](#) packaging model

Why: spins up a minimal ActivityPub/Matrix homeserver pre-wired with backups, TLS and monitoring. Scoped narrowly to just federation servers rather than "all of self-hosting" — avoids the "unrealistic scope" disqualifier.

Communication Freedom / Interoperability & Bridges

3

The dominant pattern in JOSA's own inspiration set (3 of 6 projects) — highest precedent, also highest expected competition.

★ TOP PICK WhatsApp Order Bridge for Small Jordanian Businesses

inspo: [matterbridge](#) ↗ (adapter shape)

Why: cafes, home bakers and small shops in Jordan run their entire order flow through raw WhatsApp DMs — no inventory, no tracking, but customers will never migrate off WhatsApp. Bridge incoming WhatsApp Business messages into a small self-hosted structured order dashboard: business gets data ownership, customer changes nothing. Hyper-local, narrow, standards-based output (webhook), trivially demoable live on stage, and matches almost every eligibility bullet at once (real users, no forced migration, realistic scope, ownership/privacy since data lands on their own DB). This is the strongest single candidate researched.

matterbridge Gap-Filler

inspo: [matterbridge](#) ↗ directly

Why: matterbridge covers ~15 platforms already; find what's genuinely missing (Instagram DMs, a voice-note-specific bridge) and build only that adapter. Risk: competing directly against a mature, polished existing OSS project on its own turf.

RSS-Bridge Generalized to Structured Webhooks

inspo: [RSS-Bridge](#) ↗

Why: same per-source adapter pattern, applied beyond RSS — turn any closed app's public surface (App Store reviews, delivery-app order tracking) into a structured feed/webhook. Directly satisfies "extensibility."

Unified Inbox TUI

inspo: [nchat](#) ↗

Why: nchat-style single terminal inbox unifying SMS (via local Android bridge) + email + Matrix. Appeals directly to the maintainer-judge persona (a power-user tool solving their own itch), lower mainstream "real users" breadth than the WhatsApp idea above.

4

Local-First & Data Ownership

Syncthing + Pixelfed's shape: no lock-in, portable data, zero central point of control.

"Migrate Me" Universal Import Tool

inspo: [Pixelfed](#) ↗ (portability) + [Syncthing](#) ↗ (transport)

Why: ingests a Google Takeout / Instagram export / WhatsApp chat export and auto-imports it into the matching open alternative (Pixelfed, Matrix, a Syncthing folder). Closes the "here's your zip file, good luck" gap nobody currently solves — directly attacks "real problem, real users" and "user ownership & privacy" better than a pure bridge does.

Syncthing-Based Continuous Vendor-Lock Escape

inspo: [Syncthing](#) ↗ directly

Why: auto-mirrors WhatsApp media / Google Photos exports continuously into a self-hosted folder — "your own iCloud" framing for people actively leaving Apple/Google. Narrow, ongoing (not one-shot), demoable as a live sync.

Local-First Companion for Pixelfed/Mastodon

inspo: [Syncthing](#) ↗ + [Pixelfed](#) ↗ combined

Why: caches your own posts/photos locally via Syncthing so you always have an offline personal archive independent of instance uptime. Literally combines two of JOSA's own cited inspirations — strong pattern-match for

maintainer judges.

Final Call

Recommended track & idea: Track 3 — **WhatsApp Order Bridge for Small Jordanian Businesses.**

Every comparable event studied converges on the same shape: a narrow, real, boring pain point, solved by bridging or replacing one specific lock-in seam, shipped as a working self-hostable demo with clean, documented code — not an ambitious platform, not a slide deck. JOSA's own cited inspirations are all single-maintainer projects born from one person's specific frustration with one specific proprietary chokepoint, and the judges are the kind of people who wrote projects exactly like that.

The WhatsApp order bridge fits that shape almost exactly: it's hyper-local (small businesses across Jordan genuinely run on raw WhatsApp DMs today), it doesn't ask anyone to migrate off WhatsApp, it's trivially demoable live (send a message on stage, watch a structured order appear in an open dashboard), and it satisfies nearly every eligibility bullet at once — real users, practicality, realistic scope, ownership/privacy, and a clean extension point (webhook out to any tool).

Execution checklist for the win condition

- Ship visible, incremental git commits throughout the hacking period — judges are maintainers, they will check history, and this is the direct counter to the "AI slop" disqualifier.
- Write real docs: problem statement, target user, install instructions, one architecture diagram.
- Expose one clean extension point (webhook or minimal REST API) to explicitly satisfy "extensibility."
- Keep scope to one business type, one message flow (orders in, structured record out) — resist adding inventory/payments/analytics before the core loop is rock-solid.
- Demo live with a real phone sending a real WhatsApp message — no pre-recorded video, no slide-driven pitch.

Fallback options

If team skills don't line up with WhatsApp Business API integration in the time window, the next-best picks in order are: **"Migrate Me" Universal Import Tool** (Track 4 — best eligibility-criteria fit after the top pick) and **Grandma-Mode Front-End** (Track 1 — least competitive track, no precedent pressure).

Links & References

Official Event

Reclaim Hackathon site	reclaimhackathon.com ↗
Registration form	surveys.josa.ngo/index.php/724737 ↗
Event source repo	github.com/itsmohmans/reclaim-hackathon ↗
JOSA (organizer)	josa.ngo ↗
Drosos Foundation (supporter)	drosos.org ↗
JOSA Instagram	instagram.com/jordanopensource ↗
JOSA contact	josa.ngo/contact-us ↗

Inspiration Projects (JOSA-cited)

nchat	github.com/d99kris/nchat ↗
RSS-Bridge	github.com/RSS-Bridge/rss-bridge ↗
YunoHost	github.com/YunoHost/yunohost ↗
Pixelfed	github.com/pixelfed/pixelfed ↗
matterbridge	github.com/42wim/matterbridge ↗
Syncthing	github.com/syncthing/syncthing ↗

Competitive Research Sources

FOSS Hack 2023	archive.fossunited.org/fosshack/2023 ↗
FOSS Hack 2024 results	forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2024-results ↗
FOSS Hack 2025 results	forum.fossunited.org/t/foss-hack-2025-results ↗
Solid/ODI hackathon writeup	ua.news — Financial Pod finalist ↗

Decentralized Web Hackathon (Devpost)	decentralized-web.devpost.com ↗
Matrix TADHack 2015	matrix.org/blog/2015/06/16 ↗
Matrix Community Organiser Hackathon 2025	foss.events — 2025 Matrix hackathon ↗
Mozilla Global Sprint	blog.mozilla.org ↗
Decentralized Web Summit (Internet Archive)	blog.archive.org ↗
